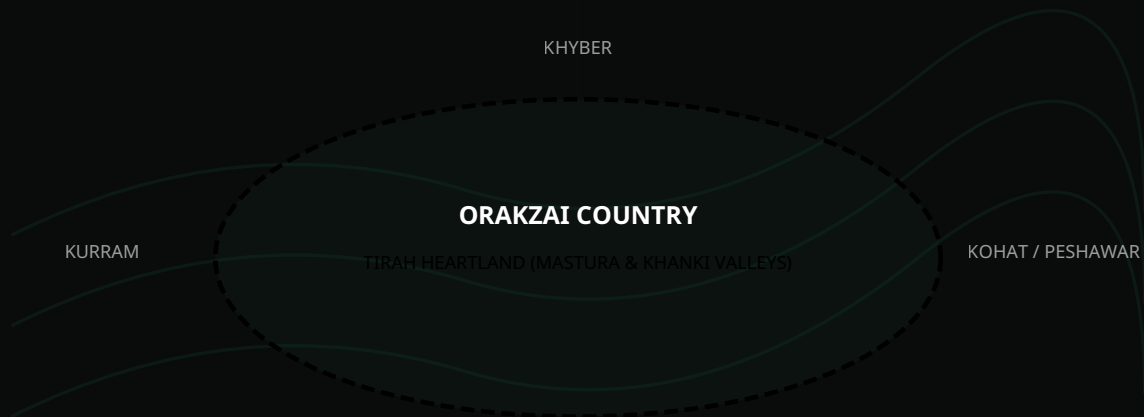


ORAKZAI TERRITORY

“Geography, landscape, and the historical homeland.”

A people are often remembered through their names. But every name also has a landscape behind it. For the Orakzai, that landscape is a country of mountains, valleys, ridges, streams, passes, and settlements in the northwestern borderlands of the Indian subcontinent.

Geography did not simply provide a backdrop to Orakzai history. It shaped movement. It shaped settlement. It influenced communication. It affected agriculture, trade, and security. And over generations, the landscape became part of collective memory and identity.¹³



“Conceptual map of the historical Orakzai homeland and surrounding border regions.”

GEOGRAPHY TO IDENTITY

The relationship between geography and society can be understood as a progressive chain of influence: mountains and river valleys determined where settlements could take root, which in turn shaped community networks, historical movements, and cultural memory.¹⁴



“Geography influences social life, but does not determine identity by itself.”

HISTORICAL TERRITORY VS. MODERN DISTRICT

It is vital to distinguish between historical "Orakzai country"—a tribal homeland defined by valleys and customary sectional boundaries—and the modern administrative **Orakzai District** established within Khyber Pakhtunkhwa following the 2018 constitutional merger. Spanning approximately 700 square miles, the region is bordered by Kurram to the west, Khyber to the north, Peshawar to the east, and Kohat/Hangu to the south.²³

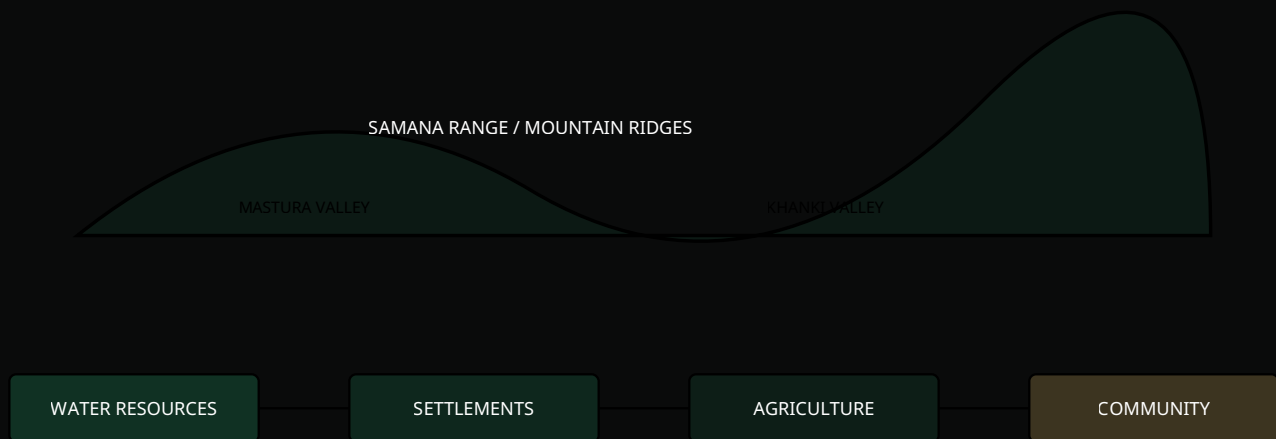
HISTORICAL ORAKZAI COUNTRY

- Tribal Homeland & Valleys
- Customary Sectional Boundaries
- Tirah Heartlands (Mastura & Khanki)

MODERN ORAKZAI DISTRICT

- ~700 Square Miles Administrative Area
- Merged into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (2018)
- Constitutional & Civic Governance

“Distinguishing between historical tribal territory and modern administrative boundaries.”



“The foundational role of river systems in supporting local habitation and agriculture.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

When I examine the map of Orakzai country, I do not see mere coordinates or administrative borders. I see the Mastura and Khanki valleys where generations of families built homes, farmed terraces, and gathered in village hujras. The mountains and rivers were witnesses to our history—they defined our isolation and our resilience. Understanding our territory means recognizing that our identity is rooted not just in abstract ancestry, but in the enduring earth of our ancestral homeland.

“A people’s history is written in their memories, but its foundation is laid in their land.”

